



Metropol Parasol

A light and spacious wooden canopy that stands on ancient remains and houses one of Seville's most vibrant markets



S. Europe

△ GIANT MUSHROOMS

Because of its distinctive shape, the new market is nicknamed *Las Setas de la Encarnación*—the Spanish for “mushrooms”—is *las setas*.

Seville's Plaza de la Encarnación has been home to a food market since the mid-19th century. The original, dilapidated market buildings were pulled down in 1973, and the traders moved into one corner of the square. Their temporary exile lasted for nearly four decades, when a new market, over an underground car park, was planned. However, construction stopped when ancient Roman and Moorish-era ruins were discovered at the site.

Mushrooms and fig trees

A competition for a structure to cover the ruins and provide a new site for the market was won by the German architect Jürgen Mayer, who was inspired by the vaults of Seville's Cathedral of St. Mary of the See (see p.143) and by the weeping fig trees that grow in the nearby Plaza de Cristo de Burgos.

The Metropol Parasol is built on four levels. Underground Level 0 contains a museum housing the Roman and Moorish remains discovered on site. Level 1 houses the market, and its roof holds an open-air public plaza sheltering under the wooden parasols above. Levels 2 and 3 hold panoramic terraces and restaurants that offer some of the best views of the ancient city of Seville.



△ A MODERN INTERLOPER

One of the largest timber structures ever built, the wooden canopy of the new market is in great contrast to the older, more sedate buildings of Seville that surround it.

BIRCHWOOD STRUCTURE

The Metropol Parasol has been described as the largest wooden building in the world. It consists of six connected parasols or umbrellas shaped like giant mushrooms. Each parasol consists of a mesh of straight wooden panels and beams glued together and sculpted into curves. The graceful structure opened for trading and enjoyment in 2011.

